

INDIA MARK II

■ By Chitra Subramanyam

The bumpy 4 km road to Rangpuri Pahari Nala, a small village off the road that leads to the Indira Gandhi International Airport in Delhi, is unpaved and rocky, amid a bramble-strewn keekar forest. The stone quarries where 600 families once worked, have been silent for long. Fifty-year-old Santosh ties her bright duppatta around her head and pumps the handle of a dull grey metal contraption. Once, twice and the water trickles into a line of plastic buckets and bottles. She stops for a breather. Her hands hurt, she says, but this is her only source of water. The other option is to walk 4 km, which will take her an hour, to

Rangpuri village where there are water pipelines. She works the hand pump again, as two other women stand, gossiping and waiting their turn.

For many like her in villages all over the country, the India Mark II hand pump has been a revolution that has made water an accessible commodity. The evolution of this lowly device began in the 1950s when the Indian government noted that there were nearly 1,53,000 villages in hard-rock areas, where water was scarce. In 1975, UNICEF, the World Health Organisation and the

WATER WISE: Women use the India Mark II pump in Rangpuri Pahari Nala, Delhi

Water MARK

It was a device designed for India's thirsty villages. The India Mark II hand pump, which was scattered throughout the country by the 1970s, was an invention truly democratic in nature.

